

came across as someone who loved life, a belief that was reaffirmed when she said that she might just celebrate her birthday by rewatching one of her favourite films, *The Birdcage*, starring Robin Williams.

The singer was readying for a tour abroad and a quick rehearsal run was on the day's agenda. The troupe that would travel with her had gathered at an apartment-turned-studio close to Burman's home in Khar. Bhosle picked out one note on the trumpet that hit two or three octaves lower than it should have. "This would work if Usha (Uthup) was going on tour with me. Why are you going so low?" she asked the musician as she effortlessly swapped her vocal timbre for Uthup's. In a video interview from 1988, Burman and Bhosle are seen rehearsing the track 'Chal saheli jhoom ke' from *Anokha Rishta* (1986). Says Burman of Bhosle in the interview, "She has a tremendous knack of (sic) copying people. If she talks to you, she will mime you. She will try to copy your voice, the way you talk.... That must have helped her. She knows the person who has composed the music and how he has imagined (the song) and she follows his way of singing, the way of diction.... That's why she does so well." Bhosle recalled how the composer's interest in multiple genres from across the world, including bossa nova and jazz, inspired her to reinvent her vocal delivery to suit the Western musical arrangements.

'LIKE NO OTHER'

Just as she dominated the 1970s with Burman's nightclub hits, she also owned the '50s and '60s with O.P. Nayyar's signature melodies driven by *tonga gaadi* (horse cart) beats. "The artistes that I chose to work with made my songs original.... But Asha was like no other. She could sing any kind of song," Nayyar told me in an interview in 2004. Bhosle credited Nayyar for drawing her out of her shell in Raju Bharatan's *Asha Bhosle: A Musical Biography*. Their collaboration led to some of her earliest hits, including 'Leke pahla pahla pyaar' from *C.I.D.* (1956). The song featured other playback stars from that time, including Shamshad Begum and Mohammed Rafi, but Bhosle would not remain on the sidelines for long. In the same year, her solo with music director S.D. Burman, 'Ae jani jeene mein kya hai' from *Funtoosh*, would mark what was perhaps her earliest nightclub hit.

Composers like A.R. Rahman would later seek out Bhosle for the frantic breathwork that she made famous in her cabaret songs, to voice a modern-day siren in the Tamil romantic drama, *Alaipayuthey* (2000), starring Shalini Ajith and R. Madhavan. Bhosle sings 'September Madham', a song that only half-jokingly mourns the end of bachelorhood, with a throaty sensuousness that lends VJ-turned-actor Sophiya Haque a sexual charge that filmmaker Mani Ratnam uses as a musical plot device.

If it wasn't the cabaret girls, it would be the courtesans confined inside their kothas who found a voice in Bhosle. Music director Khayyam, who gave Bhosle her first nightclub track in 'Suhana hai ye mausam' in *Footpath* (1953), is also credited with